Kai Gu

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Education

Bocconi University — **Milan, Italy**
PhD in Marketing — 2026 – Present

Bocconi University — **Milan, Italy**
MSc in Data Science — 2024 – 2026

Zhejiang University — **Hangzhou, China**
BEcon in Economics — 2020 – 2024

Research Interests

Substantive: Economics of Technology, AI, Computational Social Science
Methodological: Causal Inference, Machine Learning, Multimodal Data

Working Papers

AI Search as an Information Intermediary: Clickstream Evidence on Web Traffic
Qiaoni Shi, **Kai Gu**, and Kai Zhu

AI search retrieves web information to ground generated answers. We study this new information intermediary using U.S. desktop clickstream data observing use alongside referrals during ChatGPT Search's rollout. Referrals accompany 5.4% of ChatGPT sessions versus 31.1% of Google queries. Ad-supported sites receive a smaller share of ChatGPT than Google referrals, while reference and technical sites receive larger shares. Conventional searches (Google, Bing, Yahoo) decline after ChatGPT adoption, sooner when adoption follows ChatGPT Search's expansion to users without accounts. Among existing users, that expansion raises ChatGPT use; conventional searches show no detectable overall change but fall among households with lower prior search activity. These findings suggest AI search can reshape open-web traffic through its own referrals and changes in conventional search.

AI-Assisted Content Production on Multilingual Platforms
Kai Zhu, **Kai Gu**, and Lorenzo Lupo

Multilingual knowledge platforms serve readers of each language and maintain a stock of information across languages. We examine what AI-assisted translation contributes to each, comparing assisted and independently written Wikipedia articles in ten language editions against an English reference. In conditional comparisons, assisted articles contain about 27% more information because they transfer more of the English reference. They add about half as much information that the English reference lacks, so the pairwise knowledge stock is about 9% smaller. A reader of the target language finds more, and a reader or an AI system drawing on both languages finds less across the pair. These findings support evaluating AI-assisted production through both reader access and contributions to the knowledge stock.

Conference Presentations

12th CEPR Text-as-Data Workshop (Online) — September 2026
ISMS Marketing Science Conference, Lisbon, Portugal — June 2026
Bocconi Marketing Research Camp — May 2026
13th Wiki Workshop (Online) — March 2026

Skills

Languages: English, Mandarin
Programming: R, Python, LaTeX, Markdown